



# HANUMAN

## BOY WARRIOR

Genre: Third person action  
Platform: PlayStation 2  
Studio: Aurna Technologies  
Publisher: Sony Computer Entertainment  
Number of players: 1

Score: 1/10



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**H**anuman: Boy Warrior is the first console game with Indian intellectual property and developed entirely in India. Created by Aurna Technologies for the PS2, it sets into motion Sony Computer Entertainment India's plans to start infusing a steady stream of localised content for the PS2 into the Indian market, even as studios and publishers elsewhere around the world are moving on from the PS2, towards the newer generation of consoles.

So the first of the many promised Indian PS2 games is finally here, and sadly it couldn't have turned out any worse. *Hanuman: Boy Warrior* is a third-person action game with heavy emphasis on platforming. Aurna proudly proclaimed that it had developed the game in only ten months; and it shows. The game is found severely wanting in nearly every department, and even the popularity of the Hanuman character with kids and families is not enough to salvage this train wreck.

For starters, the camera angles are overly restrictive, and at times make it nearly impossible to progress beyond a particular point. The inability to move the camera vertically makes it difficult to spot high platforms that you will need to climb to in order to progress through the level. There are also segments where you're required to get from one place to another by swinging across vines. Negotiating these sections is more a matter of luck than skill, because the same effort will at times lead to failure, and at other times you'll get to your destination just fine. But you'll more often than not fail a few times before the game decides you've suffered enough and lets you progress.

Visually, Hanuman would probably fall in the category of a bad PS2 launch title. The environments and characters seem extremely bland. Animations are some of the worst I've ever seen, particularly the jump animations, where there is almost no movement in the legs while jumping. Character animations, besides looking bad, also adversely affect gameplay. Like Hanuman, the enemies too have a limited set of animations and there is no attack animation to speak of, so you never know when they're really attacking you; they just seem to skid around and bump into you to cause damage.

Combat is standard hack 'n' slash fare. Hanuman starts out with basic light and heavy attacks. An hour or so into the game, he receives his golden mace, which also adds special moves to his combat arsenal. Again, combat is held back by the lack of animations and shifts from movement to combat, and between various combat animations is extremely jerky and delayed, which means that getting the timing right in your attacks is near impossible.

*Hanuman: Boy Warrior* can be played either in English or Hindi, and all dialogues and on-screen prompts will be in your chosen language. We played the game for a few minutes at the launch party, and recalled how horrible the English was. While playing, we chose Hindi, picked the easiest difficulty – Saral – and got on our way. We were shocked to find that the script-writing and voice acting in Hindi was even worse. Voice acting in particular was shockingly bad and sounded like the actors were reading off a piece of paper, sometimes without punctuation and almost always without any expression.

No matter how hard we look, there's nothing remotely positive to write for *Hanuman: Boy Warrior*. Even if this isn't a game targeted at the serious gamer, there are way too many flaws here even to hold a casual gamer's attention. So it becomes impossible to justify at all why anyone should pony up cash for this one, even if it does cost only 500 bucks. If you're feeling generous and would like to support the Indian gaming industry and its first console game, then pick this up. But if you intend to actually play it, save your money for one of the many other quality PS2 titles available for the same price. ■

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